

ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

> **"I wanted to be independent. Today, I can proudly say that I have contributed financially to my son's education"**
>
> **Minati Sabat,** *Mission Shakti entrepreneur*

177 blocks in 30 districts with procurement of ragi up from 17,000 quintals in 2018-19 to 604,000 quintals in 2022-23. The government offers a minimum support price of Rs 3,846 per quintal for ragi, against Rs 2,183 per quintal for paddy. This has been a major source of inspiration for ragi farmers.

Odisha was awarded the best performing millets promotion state (2021) and best state for scaling up millets mission (2022) by the Centre. "Millets were always a part of the diet in the tribal districts. They grew the crop since it consumes less water than paddy and can be cultivated in the non-irrigable highlands. The push to promote millets was to improve livelihoods of vulnerable farmers," says a senior officer at the Millet Mission. The transformation has been such that consumption of millets-based food is now popular in Bhubaneswar. Minati says preparations like dahi vada and cookies sell like hot cakes. "From millets laddoo, ragi cookies and bhujiya to millets grains and noodles, we sell everything," she says.

One reason why her ALF shot to fame was their efforts during the Covid-induced lockdown in 2021. Her group started offering 40 types of pitha (pancakes) in their ward and started door-to-door delivery services of dry rations, vegetables and fruits. Minati is proud that she doesn't depend on her family financially. "We were never deprived, but I wanted to be independent," she says, explaining why she formed the SHG. "Today, I can proudly say that I have even contributed financially to my son's education." Her son Rudra Pratap, a mechanical engineering graduate, is now employed in Mumbai. ■

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

↘ The Millet Shakti outlet at Kalinga Stadium, Odisha, makes a monthly profit of Rs 3 lakh. It sells 32 millets-based cooked and dry items and has helped Minati Sabat and her 15-member team become financially independent

↘ Odisha's Mission Millet scheme has 1,993 SHGs under it, working at multiple levels

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vices and procure goods through the SHGs and give them a business of Rs 5,000 crore till 2024. Currently, some 7 million women are organised in 600,000 groups under Mission Shakti.

Sujata Karthikeyan, commissioner-cum-secretary, department of Mission Shakti, says the intention was never just to link the SHGs with banks so that they can avail loans. "Unless they are linked with the government, our women will not get the exposure they need, their participation will not be maximised and entrepreneurship-building will not happen. So, we took a different approach," she says.

The Mission Millet initiative has involved a total of 1,993 groups at multiple levels. Currently, 738 SHGs are involved as threshers, 14 work as cleaner-grader-destoner of ragi crops, even as these groups run 184 Millet Shakti tiffin centres along with seven Millet Shakti cafes and nine Millet Shakti on Wheel services. The Millet Mission, launched in 2017, now covers